

Asking questions

Topic Question forms; asking and answering questions

Level: SfL **E2+** / SQA **Access 3+** / CEFR **A2+**

Time: 75 minutes (possibly more with extension activities)

Aims

- To develop the students' ability to form questions
- To give students practice in asking and answering questions
- To promote learner autonomy by encouraging students to analyse language with a focus on form, meaning and pronunciation.

Introduction

This lesson is about the people in the room and can be use with a variety of levels. Students are given the opportunity to talk about themselves as they develop their ability to ask and answer questions. The focus is on accurate question formation through discussion, peer-correction and student interviews.

There are no materials to prepare for this lesson.

This lesson is based on the principles of Dogme English Language Teaching. To familiarise yourself with the idea of dogme teaching look at the following resources:

<http://www.teachingenglish.org.uk/seminars/20-steps-teaching-unplugged>

<http://www.teachingenglish.org.uk/seminars/live-lesson-dogme>

Teaching Unplugged by Scott Thornbury and Luke Meddings available at:

<http://www.deltapublishing.co.uk/titles/methodology/teaching-unplugged>

Meddings, L. and Thornbury, S. 2009. *Teaching Unplugged*. Peaslake: Delta Publishing.

However, the students will need the following: **a pen, a pencil, and lined paper**

Procedure

Warmer (10-20 minutes)

- Draw a question mark on the board to elicit that the lesson topic is 'questions'.
- Put the students in pairs and ask them to think of examples of questions they have asked or been asked recently.
- Write one question from each pair on the board, making sure that the common elements line up as in the table below. Note – It is a good idea to include example questions with different verb forms and with or without question words.

Examples:

	<i>Do</i>	<i>you</i>	<i>like</i>	<i>coffee?</i>	
<i>Where</i>	<i>do</i>	<i>you</i>	<i>come</i>		
			<i>from?</i>		
<i>What</i>	<i>are</i>	<i>you</i>	<i>doing</i>		<i>next</i>
					<i>weekend?</i>
	<i>Have</i>	<i>you</i>	<i>visited</i>	<i>America?</i>	

- Ask the students the following questions about the examples they have given. These are suggestions; you may think of more:
 - Why do we ask questions?
 - What words do we use when we ask questions? (who, what, where etc)
 - How do we pronounce a question?

Intonation – usually:

- the speaker's voice goes down at the end of the question, if it starts with a question word.
- the speaker's voice goes up at the end of the question, if it starts with a verb.

- How do we form questions?

Question formation guidelines for teacher:

- Example statement: I like coffee. (*I* is the **subject**, *like* is the **verb**)
- Example question: Do you like coffee? (*You* is the **subject**, *do* is the **dummy auxiliary to make a question**)
- Example statement: I am from England. (*I* is the **subject**, *am* is the **verb**)
- Example question with inversion: Where are you from? (*You* is the **subject**, *are* is the **verb**)

- Tell students to make a table like the one below and add questions that were generated in the warmer. Encourage the students to practise their intonation.

Question word	Auxiliary verb	Subject	Main verb/ participle	Object	Adverbs (place, time. etc.)
	<i>Do</i>	<i>you</i>	<i>like</i>	<i>coffee?</i>	
<i>Where</i>	<i>do</i>	<i>you</i>	<i>come from?</i>		
<i>What</i>	<i>are</i>	<i>you</i>	<i>doing</i>		<i>next weekend?</i>

Task 1 – Writing questions (10 minutes)

- Elicit 2-3 topic areas from the students that they would like to ask their classmates. Alternatively, give the students these topics yourself.
 - Sport
 - Food and drink
 - Free-time activities
 - Family
- Set a time limit of 5 minutes and ask the students to write down as many questions on the topics as they can. The students should **use pens to write their questions**. The students should leave at least 3 blank lines between each question they write.
- Give the students a further 2-3 minutes to read through their questions and make sure they are happy with them.
- **IMPORTANT – do not provide any help with language at this point** (apart from spellings, if the students are really struggling).

Task 2 – Peer-checking (10 minutes)

- Ask the students to swap their list of questions with a partner.
- Tell them to check the questions, referring back to what you discussed about questions at the beginning of the lesson.
- Students should write any corrections on **the line below the question in pencil**.
- Monitor and help any students who are struggling with the task.
- Ask questions to help students notice the form of the questions:
 - Do you need an auxiliary verb (do/does) in this question?
 - Are the words in the right order?
 - Is the spelling alright?
 - Are there any words missing?

Task 3 – Self-checking (5 minutes)

- Ask the students to return the questions to their partner.
- Tell students to read the suggested changes and rewrite any questions with errors.
- Monitor and help any students who are struggling with the task.

Task 4 – Student interviews (15 minutes)

- Ask the students to work with a partner. This could be the same partner from the previous task or a different one.
- Tell them to choose 5 of their questions to ask their partner. They should interview each other and write down notes about their partner's answers.
- If students finish quickly, they can ask each other more questions. Again, make sure they write notes about their partner's answers.

Task 5 – Writing up the interviews (15 minutes)

- Tell students to write up their partner's answers in the form of a question and answer text. Students should group their questions according to the question topics.
- Monitor and remind students to write their questions in the second person (you) and the answers in the first person (I).
- When the students have written their texts, stick them on the wall and invite students to read each other's work.
- Ask the students to discuss anything that surprised them about their classmates.

Cooler (10 minutes)

- Put the students into groups of 3 or 4 and ask them to ask you the most interesting questions they have written.
- Say you will only answer questions that are correctly formed and that each group will be awarded a point for every correctly formed question they ask.
- If the students ask an incorrectly formed question, move on to the next group.
- Conduct a final feedback session where the students discuss what they have learnt about using questions in the lesson.

Extension activities / Homework

- Students write a short text about the person they have interviewed and read this out without saying that person's name. The rest of the class has to guess who they are talking about.
- Students pick 1 or 2 of the most interesting questions and survey class. The students write a short report about their findings. Students could work in groups to do this task.
- Students use their questions to interview people outside the class, e.g. other students in the school or college or family members. The students then report on this in the next lesson.